

Nutrition During Pregnancy

Key Nutrients for Mother and Baby

Pregnancy increases the need for several nutrients including folate, iron, calcium, protein, and iodine. A balanced diet that includes a variety of food groups supports fetal growth and maternal health. Some nutrients may require supplementation as advised by a doctor.

Key Nutrients During Pregnancy

Folate supports neural tube development, especially in the early weeks. Iron is needed for the increased blood volume. Calcium supports fetal bone development. Protein is needed for tissue growth. Iodine supports brain development.

Food Sources of Key Nutrients

Green leafy vegetables, legumes, and citrus fruits provide folate. Meat, fish, legumes, and green leafy vegetables provide iron. Milk, curd, and ragi provide calcium. Eggs, dal, and paneer provide protein. Iodized salt provides iodine.

Suggested Items:

- Spinach and other leafy greens for folate
- Dal and legumes for iron and protein
- Milk and curd for calcium
- Eggs and paneer for protein
- Citrus fruits for vitamin C (helps iron absorption)
- Iodized salt for iodine

Nutrient	Why Needed	Food Source
Folate	Neural tube	Leafy greens
Iron	Blood volume	Dal, meat, greens
Calcium	Bones	Milk, curd, ragi
Protein	Tissue growth	Eggs, dal, paneer
Iodine	Brain development	Iodized salt

Conclusion

Raw or undercooked foods, unpasteurized milk, high-mercury fish, and excess caffeine should be avoided. A doctor's guidance on supplements is important throughout pregnancy.